

Muckrakers at Work

Political parties are turning to their dirty tricks departments which are certain to make the elections the dirtiest ever

■ By Uday Mahurkar

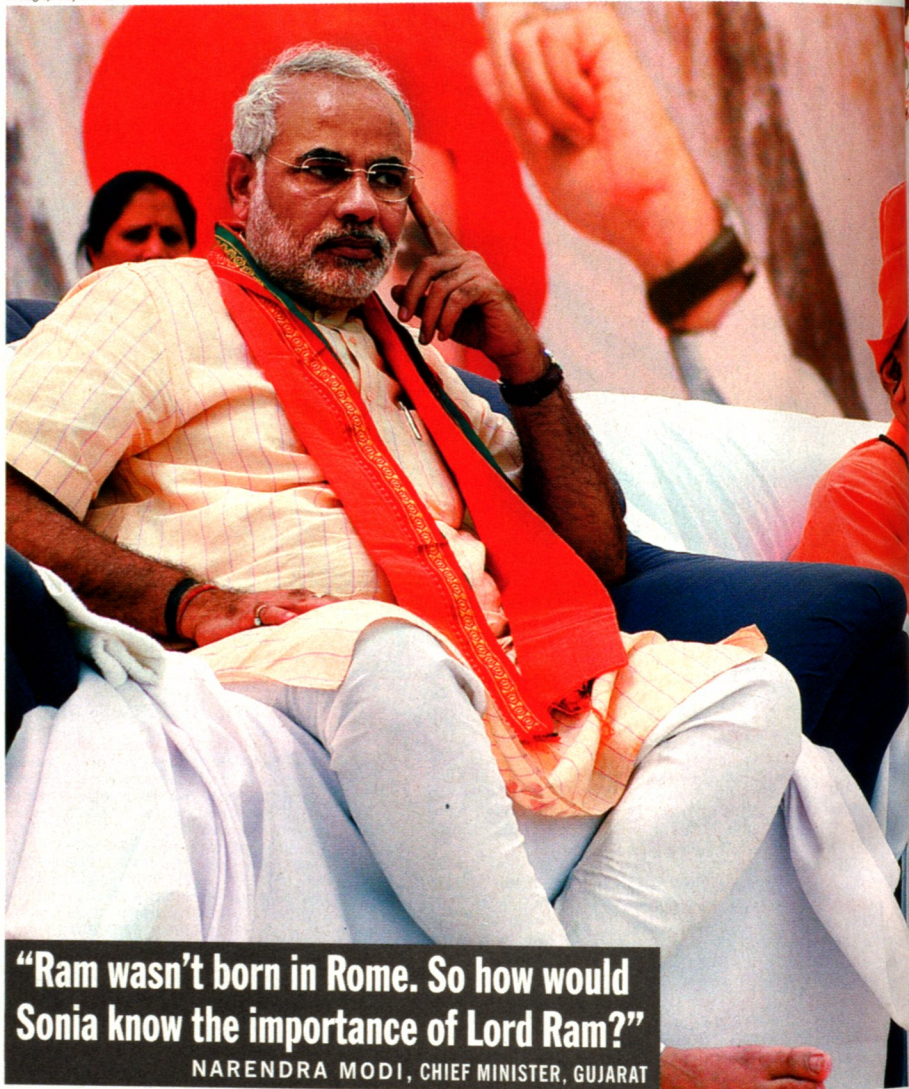
Campaign oratory has taken on a darker persona across the country. And nowhere is it more evident than in Gujarat where voters will elect a new government in December. The campaign has not yet got into top gear but politicians are already spouting venom about each other.

Sample Chief Minister Narendra Modi's remark, after the Ram Sethu controversy broke out: "Ram wasn't born in Rome. So how would Sonia behen know about the importance of Lord Ram." That was enough to invite this retort from B.K. Hariprasad, Congress general secretary in charge of Gujarat: "Modi should ponder over his own origin. People outside Gujarat do not know which gutter Modi was born in and even Modi will not know who fathered him."

Once again, retribution was swift. Addressing a public meeting at Surat, BJP state chief Purushottam Rupala dug it deep into the Congress: "The Congress should ponder over the origin of the Nehru-Gandhi family. Before Rahul, there was Rajiv before whom there was Feroze. And before Feroze who was it? Nobody knows, the Gandhi family itself does not disclose it because they know they are descendants of a Muslim family of Junagadh."

Gujarat is in for an unconventional election, which explains why all conventional canons are being thrown to the wind by the leaders. The dirty tricks departments of all the political parties are hyperactive designing a campaign that would raise lead to many an eyebrow being raised in tinpot dictatorships like Pakistan. The campaign already promises to be the dirtiest till date and the muckraking is not over the price of onions or the UPA's neglect of the state, but, as the above quotes suggest, on events that happened 60 or more

Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL



"Ram wasn't born in Rome. So how would Sonia know the importance of Lord Ram?"

NARENDRA MODI, CHIEF MINISTER, GUJARAT



FIERY: Campaign speeches provoke people to resort to vandalism

years ago—who fathered whom, when and where. Even when political leaders are not being downright abusive, the language used is volatile and aimed at eliciting strong reaction.

Modi himself has led the way with his speeches being compilation of barbs aimed at triggering laughter while earning him votes in the name of Gujarati pride. This one was from a public meeting in Surat last week: "The Congress talk about the UPA Government